

century! This means that all the preceding generations also had to be virtually perfect. Now I call that extraordinarily careful transmission. **God has preserved His Text!**

Major f³⁵ splits in Matthew

There are only five splits that might be called ‘major’ in Matthew. The reading listed first is the one that I have chosen as representing the family archetype, for reasons explained at the end of this article.

- 9:17 απολουνται [80%] || απολλυνται [20%]—the verb is the same and both are Indicative; the first is future middle and the second is present passive. In the immediately prior clauses, both εκχεται and ρηγνυνται are present passive and go together; so why the second reference to the wineskins? Any difference in meaning is almost too slight to translate.
- 19:29 οικιας [66%] || οικιαν [30%]—plural or singular? As with the brothers, if you only have one, that is all that you can leave; and if you have none, you leave none.
- 25:32 συναχθησονται [25%] || συναχθησεται [75%]—plural or singular; mass noun or not? The translation is the same.
- 26:29 γενηματος [30%] || γεννηματος [70%]—the nouns are different, the first referring to plant produce and the second to animal offspring; if the second is used of plants, it is a secondary meaning. The translation is the same.
- 27:35 βαλοντες [25%] || βαλλοντες [75%]—aorist or present? In the context any difference in meaning is so slight that the translation is the same.

As is typical of variation within the family, the difference is of one letter, except for the syllable, and Matthew is not a small book. I call this incredibly careful transmission—at no point will a reader be misled as to the intended meaning. The original wording of Matthew has been precisely preserved to our day. (The percentages within brackets are estimates, referring to the total of extant MSS for Matthew.)

I checked 114 representatives of Family 35, with reference to the five major splits, and the result is plotted on the chart below. I trust that any reasonable person will grant that the sample is adequate for my purpose (the extant Family 35 representatives for Matthew number at least 250). ++ stands for the first reading, — for the second.